



Back again: Under former Manchester United interim manager Ralf Rangnick, Austria topped its qualifying group to secure an eighth appearance at the tournament, where it achieved its best finish, third place, in 1954. AP

Scaloni has had little reason to tinker with his midfield and defence, both of which will bear a familiar look to the 2022 side.

Even though the 2018 winner, France, reached the final in 2022, the World Cup winner's curse might still linger in Argentina's memory. An early hiccup, like the one it suffered against Saudi Arabia in Qatar, could quickly conjure up those ghosts.

Against the challenge of Austria and Algeria, Argentina will have its hands full.

Algeria returns to football's biggest spectacle for the first time since 2014, when it gave Belgium a run for its money in the group stage before dragging Germany into extra time in the round of 16.

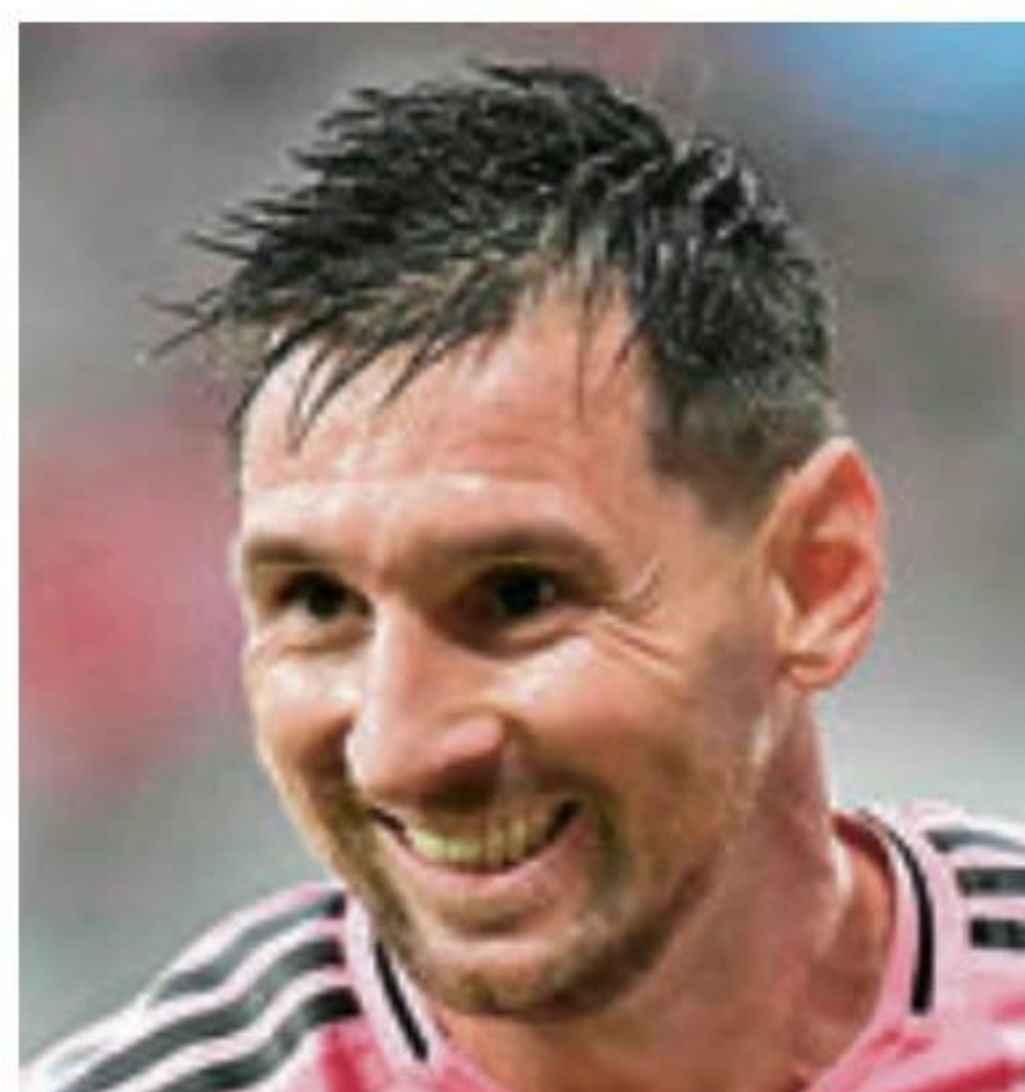
With familiar names such as Riyad Mahrez, Rayan Ait Nouri, Ramy Bensebaini and Luca Zidane in its ranks, Algeria will hardly be intimidated by the weight of the occasion. Even more so after winning eight of its 10 matches in CAF qualification.

Vladimir Petkovic, who coached Switzerland at two World Cups, has taken over and made Algeria an even stronger contender for the second automatic qualification spot.

Ensuring Algeria does not get there without a fight will be Austria's aim.

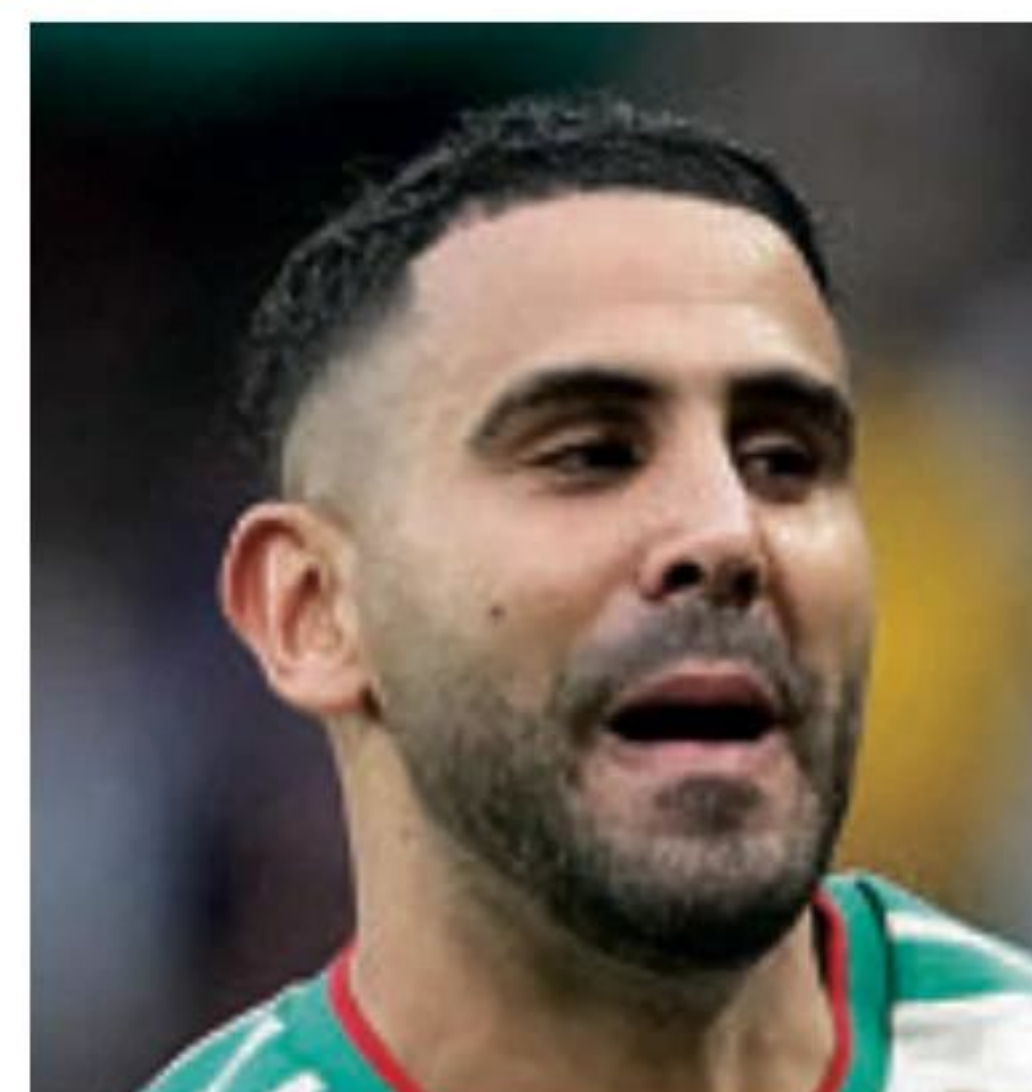
It is surprising that a team featuring David Alaba, Marcel Sabitzer, Konrad Laimer, Christoph Baumgartner and Marko Arnautovic

ON THE RADAR



Lionel Messi (Argentina)

Messi will turn 39 during the tournament and will be featuring in his sixth and final World Cup. Though away from the limelight of European football, he still runs the show for Inter Miami. Also up for grabs is the record for the highest goalscorer in World Cup history. He needs four goals to overtake Miroslav Klose's tally of 16.



Riyad Mahrez (Algeria)

Mahrez is no stranger to the grandest stage, having played for Manchester City during its treble-winning season. He has 38 goals for Algeria and is eight goals away from surpassing Islam Slimani. Doing so in four or five games might be a long shot, but at 35, Mahrez will not shy away from taking a crack.